THE
CAMPUS FOUNDER'S
PLAYBOOK

10 Things Every BTech Student
Must Know Before Building a Startup

From Classroom to Boardroom

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The Founder's Edge — LinkedIn Newsletter

For every BTech student who ever said:

“I want to build something.
I just don’t know where to start.”

Now you do.

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Foreword

A Letter to the Campus Founder

You are reading this because something inside you believes you can build something.

Maybe it is a platform you sketched in the margins of your notebook during a boring lecture. Maybe it is a solution to a problem you and your friends face every single day. Maybe it is just a feeling — an unexplained certainty that the path most people take after graduation is not the only path.

Whatever brought you here — I want you to know something before you read a single chapter of this book:

> ***The instinct to build is the most valuable thing you have. This book exists to make sure that instinct does not get crushed by a foundation that was never built.***

I have worked with over 2,000 students across India's finest institutions. I have watched brilliant people with transformative ideas fail — not because their ideas were wrong, but because nobody told them what they needed to know before they started.

Nobody told them about the co-founder agreement they should have signed in week one. Nobody explained the difference between a startup and a small business. Nobody walked them through how India's funding ecosystem actually works, or what DPIIT registration means, or why their Business Model Canvas had a fatal flaw.

Nobody gave them the playbook.

This book is that playbook.

It is not a Silicon Valley startup guide written for a world you do not live in. It is written specifically for the Indian engineering student who has the drive, the intelligence, and the technical skills to build something extraordinary — but needs a map for the terrain ahead.

Read it before you register your company. Read it before you pitch your first investor. Read it before you have the co-founder conversation that will define the next five years of your life.

Dr. Raghu Pradeep Nair
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Introduction

The Foundation Problem

A few months ago, a third-year engineering student messaged me.

He had built an AI-powered platform that connects students from different departments — technology, design, business — to collaborate on real projects and hackathons. He had already started onboarding early-stage startups onto the platform. He had a vision for how it could become the talent discovery layer for an entire university ecosystem.

The technology worked. The insight was sharp. The ambition was genuine.

When I asked him — what happens when you and your co-founder fundamentally disagree on a product decision — the room went quiet. They had never discussed it.

That silence told me everything.

> ***Most startups do not fail because the idea was wrong. They fail because the foundation was never built.***

India is the third largest startup ecosystem in the world. We have over 100,000 registered startups. We have produced more than 100 unicorns. And yet the average BTech graduate enters this ecosystem with no map.

This book addresses that gap. Each of the 10 chapters covers one foundational thing every campus founder needs to understand before they build. Read one chapter a day. Do the action steps. By the time you finish, you will have done more preparation than 90 percent of campus founders who launched before you.

That preparation is your edge.

CHAPTER ONE

Understand the Ecosystem You Are Entering

Thing 1 of 10

Before you build anything, you need to understand the world your startup will live in.

India's startup ecosystem did not happen overnight. It was built over two decades — through policy decisions, investment cycles, infrastructure development, and thousands of founders who failed before succeeding. Understanding how that ecosystem works is not optional background knowledge. It is operational intelligence you will use every single week of your founder journey.

How India's Startup Ecosystem Emerged

The story begins in the late 1990s when India's IT sector exploded. Companies like Infosys, Wipro, and TCS built India's reputation as a technology powerhouse. But they were service companies — building for clients, not building products for the world.

The first wave of Indian product startups came in the mid-2000s. Flipkart proved that Indian consumers would buy online. Then came the smartphone revolution — Jio's affordable data turned India into one of the world's largest mobile-first markets. This created the infrastructure for the second wave — Ola, Swiggy, Zomato, Razorpay.

Today, India has over 100,000 DPIIT-registered startups and more than 100 unicorns. You are entering this ecosystem at the most exciting moment in its history.

The Players — Who Does What

Founders

The people who start startups. They identify problems, build solutions, raise capital, and lead teams.

Angel Investors

High net-worth individuals who invest their own money in early-stage startups. In India, angels typically invest between ₹25 lakhs and ₹2 crores.

Venture Capital Firms

Professional investment firms that deploy capital into startups in exchange for equity. Leading Indian VCs include Sequoia Capital India (Peak XV), Accel India, Nexus Venture Partners, Matrix Partners India, and Blume Ventures.

Incubators vs Accelerators

Incubators support startups in early stages — often before the product is built. Accelerators run fixed-duration programs (3–6 months) in which selected startups receive funding and mentorship in exchange for equity.

Government Bodies

DPIIT manages Startup India. Atal Innovation Mission funds incubation infrastructure. MSME provides loans. Every state now has startup support infrastructure — Kerala Startup Mission, T-Hub, iCreate, NASSCOM.

Key Concepts from Chapter 1

- India is the third largest startup ecosystem globally — with real infrastructure, capital, and policy support
- The ecosystem has distinct players — founders, angels, VCs, incubators, accelerators, and government bodies
- Regional ecosystems — KSUM, T-Hub, iCreate — offer direct access to funding for campus founders
- BTech students have structural advantages — technical depth, institutional resources, and time to experiment

Your Action Steps

1. Research the startup ecosystem in your state — find the nearest AIC and note their application process
2. Identify 3 Indian startups founded by engineering students — study their founding stories
3. Follow 5 Indian startup investors or founders on LinkedIn this week

CHAPTER TWO

Fall in Love With the Problem, Not Your Idea

Thing 2 of 10

Every year, thousands of BTech students build products nobody uses. The technology works. The code is clean. The interface is beautiful. And yet six months after launch, the user count sits at 47.

This is not a technology problem. It is a problem-definition problem.

> ***Fall in love with the problem. Not your solution. The market will tell you whether your solution is right — but only if you are genuinely solving a problem worth solving.***

Problem vs Symptom — The Critical Distinction

Most founders solve symptoms, not problems. A symptom is what you observe. A problem is the underlying cause of that symptom. Before you define your solution, you must define your problem — precisely, specifically, and with evidence.

The Mom Test — How to Ask Questions That Give You Honest Answers

Ask questions grounded in the customer's actual past behaviour. Instead of asking 'Would you use this?' ask 'Tell me about the last time you faced this problem. What did you do? How much did it cost you?' Past behaviour is honest. Future intention is optimistic fiction.

Jobs To Be Done

Customers do not buy products — they hire products to do a job. When you think through this lens, you stop asking 'What should I build?' and start asking 'What job is the customer hiring me to do?'

How to Validate a Problem Worth Solving

- **Urgency** — Does this problem actually cause pain, cost money, or consume significant time?
- **Scale** — Does this problem affect a large number of people?
- **Frequency** — Does this problem occur frequently — daily or weekly, not once a year?

Key Concepts from Chapter 2

- Build on a problem, not an idea — the problem is the foundation
- Ask questions grounded in past behaviour, not future intention — The Mom Test
- Customers hire products to do jobs — understand the job before you build
- Validate against urgency, scale, and frequency before writing a line of code

Your Action Steps

4. Write your problem statement in one sentence without mentioning your solution
5. Interview 5 potential customers using The Mom Test — ask only about past behaviour
6. Score your problem against urgency, scale, and frequency — be honest

CHAPTER THREE

Build Your Legal Foundation Before You Build Anything Else

Thing 3 of 10

Legal ignorance is the most expensive mistake a founder can make. I have seen startup teams dissolve over equity disputes that a one-page co-founder agreement would have prevented.

Choosing Your Business Structure

Private Limited Company

The structure of choice for almost every funded startup in India. Limited liability protects founders personally. Equity can be divided into shares — making it straightforward to bring in co-founders and investors. Required for DPIIT Startup India registration.

The Co-Founder Agreement — Non-Negotiable

Sign a co-founder agreement before you write a single line of code together. Cover equity split, vesting schedule, roles and responsibilities, decision-making framework, exit clauses, and IP assignment.

> ***Do it in week one. Not week six. Not after funding. Week one.***

Intellectual Property

- **Patents** — File a provisional patent before disclosing your invention publicly. Cost: ₹1,750 for individuals.
- **Trademarks** — Register your trademark at ipindia.gov.in to protect your brand name.
- **Trade Secrets** — Use NDAs when sharing sensitive information with potential partners or investors.

DPIIT Startup India Registration

Register free at startupindia.gov.in. Benefits include 80IAC tax exemption, fast-track patent examination in 30 days, and access to the Fund of Funds. No reason not to do it.

Key Concepts from Chapter 3

- Register as a Private Limited Company for any startup seeking equity investment
- Sign a co-founder agreement before you start building — cover equity, vesting, roles, and exit
- File a provisional patent before disclosing your invention publicly — ₹1,750 for individuals
- Register for DPIIT Startup India recognition — free and unlocks significant benefits

Your Action Steps

7. Research Private Limited Company registration at mca.gov.in
8. Draft a one-page co-founder agreement covering equity, roles, and exit
9. Check if your idea involves a patentable invention — research provisional patent filing

CHAPTER FOUR

Map Your Business Before You Build Your Product

Thing 4 of 10

Most campus founders start building before they can answer the most basic business question: how does this venture make money?

The Business Model Canvas forces you to map every critical element of your venture before you write a line of code or spend a rupee on development.

The 9 Building Blocks

1. Value Proposition

What value do you create for your customer? Be specific. Measurable. Tied to a real pain point.

2. Customer Segments

Who specifically are you building for? Not 'college students' — 'third-year BTech students at tier-2 engineering colleges in South India seeking startup internships.'

3. Channels

How does your value proposition reach your customer? Digital — app stores, social media, email — or direct outreach campus by campus.

4. Revenue Streams

If you cannot answer how your startup generates revenue, you do not have a startup — you have a project. Common models: subscription, marketplace commission, freemium, institutional licensing.

5. Cost Structure

What are the most significant costs in your business model? Fixed versus variable. Understanding this tells you how much capital you need and when you will break even.

Key Concepts from Chapter 4

- Map your business model before you build your product — the BMC forces this clarity
- The Value Proposition is the most important block — make it specific and measurable
- Revenue Streams must be defined before you launch — no revenue model means no startup
- The canvas is a living document — update it every time you learn something new

Your Action Steps

10. Download a free Business Model Canvas template from strategyzer.com and fill it completely
11. Focus first on Value Proposition and Revenue Streams
12. Share your canvas with one mentor and ask for honest feedback on the weakest block

CHAPTER FIVE

Know How Startups Get Funded in India

Thing 5 of 10

Understanding India's funding ecosystem — who invests at what stage, what they look for, and what you give up in exchange — is the framework that tells you when to raise money, how much to raise, and from whom.

The Funding Stages

Bootstrapping

Build using your own resources. Zerodha bootstrapped to profitability before considering outside investment. Bootstrap for as long as you can — every month you bootstrap is a month your equity stays with the founding team.

Angel Funding

Angels invest ₹25 lakhs to ₹2 crores at pre-seed or seed stage. They invest in people first and ideas second. Find Indian angels through Indian Angel Network, Mumbai Angels, Let's Venture, and AngelList India.

Government Grants — The Funding Most Founders Miss

- **Startup India Seed Fund** — Up to ₹20 lakhs in non-dilutive grants for DPIIT-registered startups at startupindia.gov.in
- **AIM Grants** — Atal Incubation Centres offer grants, workspace, and mentorship to early-stage startups
- **State Government Grants** — State missions — KSUM, T-Hub, iCreate — offer grants for startups registered in their state

Key Concepts from Chapter 5

- Bootstrap for as long as you can — equity stays with the founding team
- Angels invest in people first and ideas second — demonstrate coachability
- Government grants are non-dilutive — apply before raising your first equity round
- Investors evaluate team, traction, market size, and business model — in roughly that order

Your Action Steps

13. Check eligibility for Startup India Seed Fund at startupindia.gov.in
14. Research the nearest AIC and understand their grant process
15. Create a one-page startup summary — problem, solution, team, and market

CHAPTER SIX

Validate Before You Build

Thing 6 of 10

Design Thinking teaches you to validate your idea before you build it — to test the core assumptions of your startup using the cheapest, fastest methods available.

The Five Stages of Design Thinking

Stage 1 — Empathise

Understand your user deeply — not as a demographic category, but as a human being with real frustrations. Observe. Have actual conversations. Listen without defending your idea.

Stage 2 — Define

Synthesise what you have learned into a clear problem statement. Specific, human-centred, framed as a challenge to be solved — not a solution to be built.

Stage 3 — Ideate

Generate solutions without evaluating them. Quantity first. The best ideas often emerge from combining elements of several apparently impractical ones.

Stage 4 — Prototype

Build the cheapest, fastest representation of your idea that allows you to test your core assumption. A Google Form, a WhatsApp group, a wireframe. Not a full product.

Stage 5 — Test

Put your prototype in front of real users and observe what happens. Not what they say — what they do.

What is a Minimum Viable Product?

The MVP is the version of your product that allows you to collect the maximum validated learning about your customers with the minimum effort. Dropbox's MVP was a video — before a single line of product code was written, it generated 75,000 signups.

Key Concepts from Chapter 6

- Design Thinking's five stages — Empathise, Define, Ideate, Prototype, Test — prevent you from building the wrong thing
- Prototype the cheapest possible version that tests your core assumption
- An MVP is not a feature-limited product — it is the minimum investment that gives maximum learning
- Test what users do, not just what they say

Your Action Steps

16. Run a Design Thinking sprint with your team this week — from Empathise to prototype in one sitting
17. Define the single most important assumption in your business model
18. Design the cheapest possible prototype that tests that assumption — without writing any code

CHAPTER SEVEN

The Skill Nobody Teaches — Founder Readiness

Thing 7 of 10

— ✦ —

> ***The startup ecosystem invests crores in technology infrastructure. Almost nothing goes into the person holding it all together — the founder.***

Y Combinator has said publicly that the number one reason early-stage startups fail is co-founder conflict. Not market timing. Not product failure. Not competition. People.

The Five Components of Founder Readiness

1. Structured Communication

The ability to express ideas, concerns, and disagreements clearly without damaging relationships. Practice: Observe, Impact, Request — state the facts, explain the impact, make the request.

2. Decision-Making Under Uncertainty

Every significant startup decision is made with incomplete information. Write down your key assumptions. Identify the one that, if wrong, would most change your decision. Test that assumption first.

3. Resilience and Emotional Regulation

Resilience is not the absence of negative emotion. It is the ability to feel the emotion, process it, and return to productive action. Setbacks are information, not verdicts.

4. The Art of Selling Without Selling

Build a three-part story: the world before your startup (the problem), the world your startup creates (the solution), and what you need from the person you are talking to (the ask).

5. Self-Awareness and Team Design

Know yourself well enough to build a team around your gaps. The most successful founders are not the smartest in the room — they are the most self-aware.

Key Concepts from Chapter 7

- Founder Readiness — communication, decision-making, resilience, selling, and self-awareness — determines startup survival
- Co-founder conflict is the number one reason early-stage startups fail
- Resilience is not the absence of negative emotion — it is the ability to process setbacks and keep moving
- Know yourself well enough to build a team around your gaps

Your Action Steps

19. Identify your greatest strength and greatest developmental gap as a potential founder
20. Practice the Observe, Impact, Request framework in one conversation this week
21. Write your startup's three-part story — before, after, and ask — and practice in under two minutes

CHAPTER EIGHT

Build Your Team Like Your Life Depends On It

Thing 8 of 10

Your team is your most important product. Before your startup has revenue, before it has customers — it has people. And the quality of those people determines whether everything else is possible.

Co-Founder Selection

- Complementary skills — cover the essential capabilities without significant gaps
- Aligned values — shared fundamentals about how you work and what you are building
- Shared commitment — both founders must be equally invested
- The ability to disagree well — can you reach a decision and move forward without the relationship breaking?

Equity Distribution

Use a vesting schedule with a one-year cliff. If a co-founder leaves before twelve months, they earn no equity. After the cliff, equity vests monthly over the remaining three years. This protects the company from early departures.

Building a Culture Deliberately

Culture is not what you say your startup stands for. It is what you do when it is inconvenient to do it. Build it deliberately from day one with three practices:

- Weekly team meeting — accomplishments, current work, blockers
- Real-time feedback — positive and corrective — as normal daily work
- Celebrate learning from failure as much as you celebrate success

Key Concepts from Chapter 8

- Your team is your most important product — hire for values first, skills second
- Co-founder selection: complementary skills, aligned values, shared commitment, ability to disagree well
- Use a vesting schedule with a one-year cliff to protect the company
- Build culture deliberately from day one

Your Action Steps

22. Map the skills your startup needs — identify gaps in the current team
23. Have an honest conversation about equity and vesting with your co-founder
24. Write three specific behaviours that represent your startup's values

CHAPTER NINE

Understand Money Before You Run Out of It

Thing 9 of 10

More startups die from running out of cash than from any other single cause. Not because the founders were careless — because they did not understand their financial position.

The Five Financial Concepts Every Founder Must Know

1. Burn Rate

The amount of money your startup spends each month. Track it weekly — not monthly. By the time a monthly report shows you a problem, you may have two weeks of cash left.

2. Runway

Runway = Cash in Bank ÷ Monthly Burn Rate. The minimum safe runway is 12 months. If you have less than 6 months, you are in crisis mode — whether you know it or not.

3. Unit Economics

LTV must be at least 3 times your CAC for a sustainable business model. If your LTV is ₹6,000 and your CAC is ₹1,000 — healthy. If your LTV is ₹1,500 and your CAC is ₹1,000 — you are barely making money on each customer.

4. Break-Even

Break-even = Fixed Monthly Costs ÷ Gross Margin per Customer. This tells you the minimum number of customers you must have before your startup is financially sustainable.

5. Revenue Model

Define exactly how your startup makes money — subscription, marketplace commission, freemium, B2B institutional — before you launch.

Key Concepts from Chapter 9

- Burn rate and runway are the two numbers that determine your startup's survival — track weekly
- LTV must be at least 3x your CAC for a sustainable business model
- Know your break-even point — the minimum customers at which you are financially sustainable
- Review your financial dashboard every Monday

Your Action Steps

25. Calculate your startup's projected monthly burn rate
26. Calculate your runway at this burn rate with your current or projected capital
27. Define your LTV and CAC assumptions — do the numbers support a sustainable business?

CHAPTER TEN

Your First 90 Days — A Founder's Action Plan

Thing 10 of 10

Everything you have read in this book is preparation. This chapter is execution.

Days 1–7 — Foundation Week

- Have the co-founder conversation — equity, roles, decision-making, exit. Document the outcome.
- Define your problem statement — one specific sentence, no solution mentioned.
- Map your Business Model Canvas — fill all 9 blocks. Do not skip Revenue Streams.
- Identify your 10 first potential customers — actual people with names and contact details.
- Register for DPIIT Startup India recognition — free, takes 2 days, significant benefits.

Days 8–30 — Validation Month

- Contact all 10 potential customers using The Mom Test. Record what you learn.
- Build your first prototype — the simplest possible representation of your value proposition.
- Run your first user tests with 5 potential customers. Observe, do not pitch.
- Update your Business Model Canvas with what you have learned.
- Connect with your nearest AIC — attend one event, introduce yourself.

Days 31–60 — Build Month

- Define your MVP scope — build only what tests your most important assumption.
- Build your financial model — 12-month projection, break-even, capital requirements.
- Apply for one grant — Startup India Seed Fund or your state startup mission.
- Have your first mentor meeting — ask where the biggest risks are.

Days 61–90 — Launch Month

- Launch your MVP to your first 10 users — controlled release, observe everything.
- Establish your weekly rhythm — Monday review, Friday debrief.
- Build your first content piece — share what you have learned on LinkedIn.
- Define your next 90-day goals — three specific outcomes for the next quarter.
- Celebrate — you have done more in 90 days than most aspiring founders do in two years.

Key Concepts from Chapter 10

- The first 90 days sets the habits, relationships, and momentum that carry your startup forward
- Days 1–7: co-founder agreement, problem statement, BMC, first 10 customers, DPIIT registration
- Days 8–30: customer conversations, first prototype, first user tests
- Days 31–90: MVP, financial model, grant application, first users, weekly rhythm

Your Action Steps

28. Print this 90-day plan and mark today's date as Day 1
29. Complete the Day 1–7 checklist before the end of this week
30. Find one accountability partner who will check in at the end of each 30-day period

Conclusion

The Edge

You have read ten chapters. You now understand the Indian startup ecosystem. You know how to find and validate a problem worth solving. You understand legal foundations, business modelling, funding, Design Thinking, founder readiness, team building, finance, and your first 90 days.

You know things that most campus founders who have already launched do not know. That is your edge.

> ***The gap between people who want to build a startup and people who actually do is almost entirely a gap in foundation. You have built that foundation. Now build something with it.***

The Indian startup ecosystem needs founders who build with integrity. Founders who solve real problems for real people. The founders who build with integrity are the ones who last.

Be that founder.

The playbook is in your hands. The ecosystem is open. The problem worth solving is waiting.

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Coimbatore, India · 2026

About the Author

Dr. Raghu Pradeep Nair is a Startup Coach and Founder Mentor with nearly three decades of experience spanning corporate law, HR leadership, management education, and institutional governance.

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Search "Dr. Raghu Pradeep Nair" on LinkedIn

"Most startups don't fail. Most founders give up.
This book was written to make sure you are not one of them."